

Lecture 12 — Linear dependence as redundancy

Mon Sep 21

Last updated: September 22, 2026.

Reading: Boyd 5.1 (linear independence). Related objectives: [Lectures](#). [Schedule](#). Midterm 1 is Friday, October 2.

Bring paper. Warm-up while attendance is taken, then fill-in notes, board examples, and **Check yourself**.

Learning objectives

By the end of class, students should be able to:

1. Recognize simple dependent and independent collections.
2. Construct a dependence relationship.
3. Interpret dependence as redundant information.
4. Explain why redundancy matters in data, measurement, and computation.

Warm-up

Let $a = (1, 0)$, $b = (0, 1)$, and $c = (1, 1)$.

- (a) Find scalars α, β (not both zero is fine) so that $c = \alpha a + \beta b$.
- (b) In one sentence: is knowing c “new information” once you already know a and b ?

Fill in

A list of n -vectors $a_1, \dots, a_k$ is **linearly dependent** if there exist scalars $\beta_1, \dots, \beta_k$, **not all zero**, such that

$$\beta_1 a_1 + \dots + \beta_k a_k = \underline{\hspace{2cm}}.$$

Any such nontrivial combination equal to zero is a **dependence relation**.

The list is **linearly independent** if the only solution of $\beta_1 a_1 + \dots + \beta_k a_k = 0$ is $\beta_1 = \dots = \beta_k = \underline{\hspace{2cm}}$.

Equivalent picture: the list is dependent if (and only if) at least one vector is a linear combination of the others (or the list contains the zero vector).

Redundancy: if the vectors are features, sensors, or columns of data and they are dependent, then at least one measurement can be redundant from the others — it does not add a new independent piece of information.

A single nonzero vector is always independent. Two vectors are dependent iff one is a multiple of the other.

Worked in class

W1. Independent or dependent? For each list in $\mathbb{R}^2$, decide and give a one-line reason.

(a) $(1, 0), (0, 1)$

(b) $(2, 4), (1, 2)$

(c) $(1, 1), (1, -1), (0, 2)$

W2. Construct a dependence relation. For $u = (1, 2)$, $v = (2, 1)$, $w = (3, 3)$, find $\beta_1, \beta_2, \beta_3$ not all zero with $\beta_1 u + \beta_2 v + \beta_3 w = 0$. (Hint: notice $w = u + v$.)

W3. Sensors. Three temperature sensors report daily averages as vectors of length 7. Sensor C always equals (Sensor A + Sensor B)/2. Are the three weekly report vectors dependent? What does that mean for “how many independent sensors” you really have?

W4. Features. Customer vectors (age, income, spending). Someone adds a fourth feature “age in months” = $12 \times$ age. Does the new feature add independent information for linear models that use these coordinates?

W5. Zero vector. Why is any list that includes 0 automatically dependent?

Check yourself

C1. Are $(1, 0, 0)$, $(0, 1, 0)$, $(0, 0, 1)$ independent in $\mathbb{R}^3$? Brief reason.

C2. Find a dependence relation for $(1, 1)$, $(2, 2)$, $(0, 1)$.

C3. True or false: if every pair in a list of three vectors is independent, then the whole list is independent.

C4. In one sentence: why might redundant features waste storage or confuse nearest-neighbor distance?

C5. Give one independent list of two vectors in $\mathbb{R}^2$ and one dependent list of two vectors in $\mathbb{R}^2$.

Answers (Check yourself)

C1. **Yes.** If $\beta_1(1, 0, 0) + \beta_2(0, 1, 0) + \beta_3(0, 0, 1) = 0$, then $(\beta_1, \beta_2, \beta_3) = 0$, so only the trivial combination works.

C2. Example: $(1, 1)$ and $(2, 2)$ are multiples, so $2 \cdot (1, 1) + (-1) \cdot (2, 2) + 0 \cdot (0, 1) = 0$. (Any nontrivial relation that uses that fact is fine.)

C3. **False.** Counterexample: $(1, 0)$, $(0, 1)$, $(1, 1)$ — each pair is independent, but the three are dependent because $(1, 1) = (1, 0) + (0, 1)$.

C4. A redundant coordinate can overweight that direction in Euclidean distance (or store duplicated information) without adding a new independent signal.

C5. Independent example: $(1, 0)$, $(0, 1)$. Dependent example: $(1, 2)$, $(2, 4)$.